11 Supernatural Antagonists

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Credits

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A secondary dedication to the Brain Bug and all the hat quandaries…

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11 Supernatural Antagonists

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20th ANNIVERSARY EDITION

VAMPIRE

THE MASQUERADE

Introduction

"Up until today you believed there was a line between myth and reality. Maybe a very fine line sometimes but at least there was a line. Those things out there are REAL. If they're real, what else is real? You know what lives in the shadows now. You may never get another night's sleep as long as you live."

– Megan; *Dog Soldiers*

Greetings, dear reader.

Vampires will always be their own worst enemies, but the World of Darkness is a place of shadows, secrets, and mystery and there are other creatures out there, mystical beings who see vampires as enemies or rivals or possibly even a resource to be exploited.

This book presents 11 antagonists of a supernatural origin – I have gone for a mix of both physical and non-physical threats, as well as both good, old, recognizable foes (such as a Lupine) and more esoteric beings.

Have fun!

Chapter One:

11 Supernatural Antagonists

"If it bleeds, we can kill it."

— Dutch; *Predator*

1: Katherine Zantosa, The Revenant

Katherine was born, under a different first name, during the last days of the Anarch Rebellion. Her owner was an ancient Tzimisce who still held to the old traditions and as such, he was under constant attack by younger members of the clan. Katherine's father was their master's factor in the city of Buda-Pest, dealing with mortals and handling whatever trade was needed on behalf of the vampire. Katherine was brought up in this family of merchants and envoys, trained to deal with mortals in whatever way was necessary.

When the Anarchs slew Katherine's owner, she was still a young woman and, more importantly, had not yet been Blood Bonded to her master. While her parents, aunts and uncles, and other older members of the family suddenly found themselves deprived of vampiric vitae, Katherine herself was free. However, the young Tzimisce behind the attack knew about the various revenant families and so, they began to hunt down the former servants, either to kill them or to, somewhat ironically, enslave them and use them in the battle against the hated Elders. Katherine easily read the writing on the wall and liquidated as much of her family's business as she could get her hands on, before fleeing westward. Soon, she found herself in England, a place less touched by the chaos of the Anarch Revolt than most of Europe.

For a while, Katherine plied her talents as a freelance fixer among the youngest Kindred of London and the bigger cities in England, but she was always afraid that she would be caught up by some enterprising vampire and the idea of the Blood Bond terrified her. But she also knew that she needed vampire blood to stave off her slow aging, so she could not completely shut herself off from the Kindred world.

When Britain took an interest in the New World, Katherine saw an opportunity. Cashing in all the favors she was owed, she journeyed across the ocean to the British colonies with a fair amount of ready cash and enough Kindred vitae to last her a while. She set herself up in Virginia and, drawing upon experience

from the old world, established one of the first brothels in the British colonies.

At first, the vampires that came to the New World were Sabbat, the heritors of the Anarch legacy, who were aware of the existence of revenants, and Katherine hid herself from them. However, with British interests on the rise, more and more Camarilla Kindred made the trip. And Katherine was ready to supply their need for blood, acquired discretely.

Over time, Katherine moved from city to city, always aiming for the biggest and wealthiest centers of civilization, though avoiding the Sabbat as much as possible. Over the centuries, she has built up a business empire; on the surface, she is the owner of a small, but supremely exclusive, model agency. However, she is also the manager of a nation-wide escort agency, holds controlling interest in a make-up firm and, through intermediaries, she controls a few high-class brothels.

Katherine's goals are simple – she wants to survive and she wants to remain free from any vampiric influence. She does her best not to spend whatever Kindred vitae she acquires, but at least once every decade, she finds herself needing a "top-up". When this happens, she will turn her attention to the vampires who owe her favors and ask for payment in blood.

Katherine has used her Vicissitude to significantly alter her looks over the years. She appears as a beautiful woman of medium height and build, with shoulder-length, silver-blond hair and blue eyes. Katherine is always dressed appropriately for the situation, with subtle, but expensive jewelry.

Character Involvement: Katherine likes to ensnare Kindred and then take payment in blood. She is willing to let vampires use her "services" without proper payment, with them owing her a favor later. Either the characters or perhaps their sire or a childe could end up in this situation.

Katherine is also quite protective of her business and will try to oust anyone setting up a similar enterprise. In addition, she will not take kindly to anyone abusing those who work for her, so any character who loses control and damages or kills one of Katherine's people will earn her enmity – and while she will not physically confront vampires, she has quite a number of favors and contacts to call on.

Nature: Survivor

Demeanor: Director

Apparent Age: Late 30s

Physical: Strength 2, Dexterity 4, Stamina 3

Social: Charisma 4, Manipulation 5, Appearance 4

Mental: Perception 4, Intelligence 3, Wits 5

Talents: Alertness 3, Athletics 2, Awareness 2, Brawl 2, Empathy 4, Expression 1, Intimidation 3, Leadership 4, Subterfuge 5

Skills: Animal Ken 1, Crafts 3, Drive 1, Etiquette 5, Firearms 1, Melee 1, Stealth 1

Knowledges: Academics 1, Finance 2, Investigation 1, Law 2, Medicine 1, Occult 3, Politics 3

Disciplines: Auspex 3, Celerity 1, Fortitude 1, Potence 1, Presence 3, Vicissitude 3

Backgrounds: Allies 3 (Powerful people using her services), Contacts 5 (In numerous, useful places), Fame 1, Influence 1, Resources 3

Virtues: Conscience 2, Self-Control 5, Courage 3

Morality: Humanity 6

Willpower: 9

Blood Pool/Max per Turn: 15/3

2: Raging Howl, The Lupine

Vampires fear the wilderness between the cities and with good reason, for it is the domain of the werewolves and they hate vampires. However, in the cities, the Kindred are safe from the predations of the Lupines. Or so they think.

Truthfully, the Lupines hate the cities – they live in the wilderness because it is their home and in the city, they are spiritually cut off. But every once in a while, a werewolf will leave the wilds and enter the city – Raging Howl is one of these urban wolves.

Originally, Raging Howl was a member of a small pack, but impulsive indiscretion on his part got most of his pack mates killed in a battle against a powerful spirit being. Shunned by his family, Raging Howl entered the city, ostensibly to atone for his sin by removing himself to an unfriendly environment and there, hunting and killing vampires. However, he is also driven by a subconscious death wish.

In his human form, Raging Howl lives as a homeless man in the city's largest park. By day, he scrounges up what he can or spends money taken from his victims. At night, he prowls the streets for those victims - vampires who unintentionally reveal themselves. Raging Howl has become quite adept at recognizing vampires, not just from their pallor, but also from their habits, feeding patterns, where they congregate, etc.

Raging Howl has little subtlety – he does not parley or try and tricks, he simply attacks vampires and tries to kill them, retreating if he is met with overwhelming force.

Character Involvement: While Raging Howl is mainly a physical challenge, the characters need not get involved just by being attacked by him. They may hear rumors of a wolf-man stalking the streets of their domain or preferred hunting ground and chose to investigate. They may come across one of Raging Howl's victims or have one of their allies or childer killed by the Lupine. They may even randomly come across a battle between Raging Howl and one or more vampires, forcing them to decide whether they want to join or not.

Another option is to have one or more Kindred disappear, with the characters investigating, either on their own or by decree from some high-ranking vampire, and then slowly let them realize just what they are up against – a Lupine in the city.

Attributes (human form): Strength 4, Dexterity 4, Stamina 4, Charisma 3, Manipulation 1, Appearance 3, Perception 4, Intelligence 2, Wits 3

Abilities: Alertness 4, Animal Ken 2, Athletics 4, Awareness 2, Brawl 4, Crafts 1, Expression 1, Intimidation 3, Investigation 1, Medicine 1, Occult 2, Stealth 3, Streetwise 1, Survival 2

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 1, Celerity 4, Fortitude 4, Obfuscate 1, Potence 2, Protean 4

Humanity: 5, **Willpower:** 8, **Gnosis:** 6

3: Darnelle Jones, The Ghost

Darnelle was just a young law student who enjoyed going out on the odd week-end with her friends. A pretty, but not spectacularly beautiful, woman, Darnelle got a fair amount of attention from both genders and found herself more than once having to defend her sexuality from men wanting to convert her.

Darnelle's death came after one of those nights, fending off wandering hands and enduring foul language from scorned men. Drawing upon her connections at the bar, Darnelle slipped out the back way in order to avoid more attention – and exited straight out into a vampiric feeding. Darnelle does not remember much; someone was drinking blood from a friend of hers, she screamed, red fangs, and then darkness.

Darnelle's rage, confusion, and desire both to protect her friends and gain revenge made her a ghost. Her first action was to look in on her friend, who had apparently survived. However, over the next days, it became clear to Darnelle that her friend's mind had been altered so that she did not remember the encounter.

After this, Darnelle dedicated her existence to learn as much as possible about vampires, their powers, their strength, and their weaknesses. It quickly became clear to Darnelle that her abilities to influence the real world were limited and she has done her best to develop powers that allows her to influence the land of mortals.

Darnelle has become quite a thorn in the side of the city's Kindred, without them realizing who is causing trouble. An intelligent and patient woman, Darnelle has been doing her best to ruin feedings, draw attention to vampires and generally make a nuisance of herself. Her ultimate goal is to protect her friend and break the vampiric mind control, but in a broader sense, she wants to protect mortals from vampires. If she were to meet Kindred with high Humanity, she might agree to help them, once they convince her that they too want to the limit vampires' predations on humans.

Character Involvement: Possibly, the character who originally killed Darnelle is one of the player's characters, or that vampire asked one of the PCs to use mind-affecting Disciplines to keep Darnelle's friend from talking. The characters could also find themselves targeted by the vengeful ghost, especially if they have killed (and even more especially if they have killed during feeding). Characters with high Occult scores or a facility for Auspex may be called upon to investigate a haunting or they may themselves come across signs of Darnelle's activities. Finally, they may be tasked with handling a Masquerade breach engineered by Darnelle and become aware of the ghost that way.

Attributes: Strength 0/2, Dexterity 3, Stamina 2, Charisma 5, Manipulation 2, Appearance 3, Perception 3, Intelligence 4, Wits 3

Abilities: Academics 2, Alertness 2, Athletics 1, Awareness 4, Brawl 1, Computer 1, Crafts 1, Drive 1, Empathy 3, Etiquette 1, Intimidation 1, Investigation 1, Law 2, Occult 3, Politics 1, Stealth 1, Streetwise 1, Subterfuge 1

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 2, Chimerstry 2, Dementation 1, Dominate 1, Vicisstude 1

Humanity: 7, **Willpower:** 9, **Passion Pool:** 6

4: Aurial, The Demon

On Tuesday, October 29th, 1929, the Wall Street stock market crashed. This followed the London Stock Market crash from the month before and sent the international economy into a downward spiral.

As their fortunes dwindled, six businessmen, who had been members of the same occult brotherhood at university, met in order to enact a desperate plan. In their youth, they had thought the brotherhood an old and quaint fraternity, whose members enjoyed the trappings of ritual and mystique, but in the end, simply a way to take drugs, spend a fun evening, and make connections for the life after graduation. Now, they dug out one of the old books and prepared a ritual to summon Aurial, a demon said to be able to grant wealth to those who summoned it.

Much to the surprise of all present, the ritual actually worked. In the circle, painted in the blood of a dead prostitute, a darkly handsome figure with bronze skin and blond hair appeared, naked and holding golden coins in his fist – a far cry from the homeless man the brotherhood had offered up as a sacrificial vessel to the demon.

However, the would-be occultists soon found themselves in trouble; the blood used to make their summoning circle was not exactly virgin blood, their Latin less than perfect and their willpower not exactly up to taking on a demon. Aurial easily broke the businessmen's hold over him and walked free – though he was not ungrateful. He ensured that each man was given the wealth he desired. But in one year, each man was dead, killed in a mugging, by a jilted mistress, by a jealous business partner, etc.

Since then, Aurial has established himself as a power broker in the city, a secretive figure who will help those who can find him – for a price. Most people are simply asked to do tasks that make the world that little bit darker, but for those willing to sell their souls, Aurial can offer one of his greatest prizes (see Special Power).

Aurial is extremely happy to be out of Hell and knows, that should his host be destroyed, he will go right back. As such, he does his best to avoid any direct confrontations, especially with other supernatural beings, preferring to work behind the scenes. Since he believes that vampiric souls are already damned to Hell, he has little use for them and would prefer it if vampires never knew of his existence.

Character Involvement: Rivals or enemies of the characters may go to Aurial for help or one of the tasks set by the demon might target the characters' domain. If the characters hear about someone with supernatural powers offering favors for services, they might chose to investigate on their own accord.

Attributes: Strength 2, Dexterity 4, Stamina 2, Charisma 4, Manipulation 5, Appearance 4, Perception 4, Intelligence 3, Wits 5

Abilities: Academics 1, Alertness 2, Athletics 1, Awareness 5, Crafts 3, Empathy 4, Etiquette 4, Expression 3, Intimidation 3, Investigation 3, Larceny 1, Law 3, Occult 5, Politics 3, Stealth 3, Streetwise 3, Subterfuge 5

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 2, Chimerstry 3, Daimoinon 4, Obfuscate 3, Vicissitude 3 (can only reshape the features of his host or other mortals, and then only to alter their Appearance attribute)

Special Power: If a mortal signs their soul over to Aurial of their own free will, he can grant them Resources 5 – the beneficiary's Resource rating will slowly rise over one or two months, depending on their starting point. Of course, nothing prevents the person from losing their newfound wealth if they do not take good care of it.

Humanity: 1, **Willpower:** 6, **Faith:** 8

5: Gadreel, The Fallen Watcher

According to standard angel lore, there are nine choirs of angels, the highest being the seraphim and the lowest being ordinary (sometimes called guardian) angels. However, certain apocryphal texts mention a tenth choir; the grigori, also called "the watchers".

According to these texts, God created the grigori to watch over humanity and teach them to survive outside the Garden of Eden. He instilled in them a great love for humanity, in order to ensure that they would fulfill their mission. However, this love backfired; several of the grigori took wives among humanity, giving birth to a race of people called the Nephilim – a hint of this is found in Genesis 6:4; "There were giants in the earth in those days; and also after that, when the sons of God came in unto the daughters of men, and they bare children to them, the same became mighty men which were of old, men of renown." However, all other references to the grigori were stricken from the "official" version of the Bible and is found only in apocryphal books.

Unfortunately for the watchers, taking wives was against God's commandment and so, they were cast out from Heaven. Some of them rebelled even further and joined Lucifer in Hell, while others stayed on Earth, true to their original commandment; watch over humanity.

Gadreel is one of these watchers – he was originally tasked with teaching humanity how to use weapons, so that they could defend themselves, as well as how to kill, so that they could hunt for meat. Later, during the ascent of Egypt, he taught humans how to use cosmetics in order to better endure the sun.

Having been on Earth for over ten thousand years, Gadreel has become somewhat disenchanted with his task. He has seen what humans have done with what he taught them, he has watched countless wars costing innumerable lives, and he has witnessed a cosmetics industry savagely torturing animals in pursuit of profit.

After the bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, Gadreel decided to give up on humanity at large. He settled down as a smith, making money as a knife maker while also forging weapons for those who wanted them. In modern times, Gad Reilly of Angel Forge has become a legend in reenactment circles.

While Gadreel might have grown disenchanted with humanity, he still feels compelled to help and protect humans. Millennia on Earth have given him quite a lot of knowledge about the supernatural threats that prey on humanity, vampires among them, which he will use if confronted with evidence of misdoings.

In appearance, Gadreel is a tall man with olive skin and vaguely Semitic features. His black hair hangs to his shoulders and he has a full beard.

Character Involvement: Gadreel is not an active vampire hunter, but if he realizes that vampires are causing harm to humans he deals with, or are causing wide-spread trouble for humans, he will act. The characters could encounter him if they have been especially brutal or they might find a sire, blood-relative or childe slain after an especially destructive feeding. If the characters have a working relationship with the powers-that-be, they might find themselves asked to investigate the death of one or more vampires that Gadreel has taken out.

More interestingly, if one of the characters wants a high-quality melee weapon, they might inadvertently end up at Angel Forge.

Attributes: Strength 5, Dexterity 5, Stamina 5, Charisma 5, Manipulation 3, Appearance 3, Perception 5, Intelligence 4, Wits 5

Abilities: Academics 5, Alertness 5, Athletics 5, Awareness 6, Brawl 5, Crafts 6, Empathy 5, Etiquette 3, Firearms 6, Intimidation 4, Medicine 2, Melee 7, Occult 6, Stealth 5, Survival 5

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 2, Celerity 3, Fortitude 5, Potence 3

Notes: Gadreel cannot activate his Physical Disciplines at their full potential. He soaks all damage with his full Stamina + Fortitude and is immune to mental and emotional powers, as well as Daimoinon. Since he is a fallen angel, he has no true Divine powers and no True Faith. He speaks all human languages.

Humanity: 7, **Willpower:** 10

Equipment: If expecting trouble, Gadreel arms himself with an exceptionally high-quality sword of his own making (+1 die to use and to damage)

6: Alice Beck – The Mage

Few vampires know anything about wizards, other than that it's what Clan Tremere used to be. In fact, most neonates scoff at the idea of mortal mages existing, even though they themselves have become undead. For the most part, wizards avoid vampires. They know that, if caught unawares, they are no match for even the youngest Kindred and they have little in common with the undead anyway.

Alice grew up in an archetypal broken home; absentee father, poor, hard-working mother, delinquent older siblings and a score of stepdads, some of them physically abusive. She ran away to the city at age 13 and never looked back. Had it not been for her talents, she would probably have ended up just another statistic in the endless grind of the World of Darkness. However, Alice had a gift – the gift of magic.

Unfortunately for Alice, her powers were first recognized by a burned-out neo-shaman who had more or less fried his talent (and brains) with too many drugs. He was able to kindle Alice's powers and teach her a modicum of control, but ultimately, he was a poor mentor, and abusive to boot. Eventually, Alice lost control and ended up killing her teacher with magic.

After the dust had settled, Alice found herself surprised that she felt little in the way or guilt or remorse over the murder she had just committed. In fact, she felt empowered and free in a way she had never felt before. Curious, she took to the streets and found the most abusive pimp she could and then killed him. Again, she felt the rush of power and a greater sense of clarity.

Since then, Alice has become a magical serial killer. She recognizes the problem inherent in gaining power from killing and has realized that she "only" needs to kill once a month to empower her full potential. However, the rush and the sensation of killing is a potent drug that she struggles against. So far, she has targeted drug dealers, pimps, and muggers, as well as the occasional rat, pigeon, and stray dog and her moral compass will not, for now, allow her to kill anyone she does not consider a dangerous, violent, exploitive person.

Alice knows very little about vampires – her mentor told her that they exist and that they are dangerous. However, Alice moves in the darkest part of the city and at some point, she will likely cross paths with the undead.

Alice has a pretty face, but is otherwise an unremarkable, Caucasian woman with shoulder-length, black hair, dressed in cheap, off-the-rack clothes.

Character Involvement: Characters can come across Alice randomly if they move in the same circles, or they may come across her when investigating the death of a contact, ally, or even ghoul, if they have interests among pimps and/or drug dealers.

Or, if one or more characters try to hold on to their Humanity by feeding from criminals, they might find themselves crossing paths with Alice under quite different circumstances.

Attributes: Strength 2, Dexterity 2, Stamina 4, Charisma 3, Manipulation 2, Appearance 3, Perception 4, Intelligence 3, Wits 3

Abilities: Alertness 2, Athletics 2, Awareness 4, Brawl 2, Empathy 2, Intimidation 3, Larceny 3, Medicine 1, Melee 1, Occult 3, Stealth 2, Streetwise 4, Subterfuge 2

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 3, Fortitude 1, Thaumaturgy 4 (Hands of Destruction)

Humanity: 4, **Willpower:** 9, **Quintessence:** 10

Equipment: Large knife, plenty of ready cash stolen from victims

7: The Tupilaq

A tupilaq is an avenging, destructive construct creature, made by an Inuit shaman, using dark and taboo-breaking rituals. The tupilaq is sent against someone the shaman wishes to kill, though there is a danger – if the tupilaq is sent to destroy someone with greater magical power than its creator, it will be turned against its maker.

This particular tupilaq was created in 1968 by a Greenlandic *angakkuq* (shaman) who was dying of radiation poisoning. In January of that year, a B-52G Stratofortress airplane crashed near Thule Air Base in northwestern Greenland. The high explosive components of four hydrogen bombs detonated on impact, spreading radioactive material over a large area. The American and Danish authorities moved quickly to clear away the radioactive material, using a large amount of native labor. No radiation protection was offered and the average ambient temperature was -40 degrees. The Danes and Americans overseeing the clean-up cared little for the worker safety of the Inuit workers and there were several accidents and a few deaths. As the years progressed, first radiation sickness and then cancer took their toll as well.

Knowing that he too was destined to die, the *angakkuq* violated the taboos of his people on a dark and moonless night and sent a tupilaq to destroy the man who had overseen his work detail; USAF Captain Ronald D. Carrick. Unfortunately, Carrick had been flown in specifically for the clean-up and before the tupilaq could find him at Thule Air Base, the captain was back in the US. Undaunted, the creation began its trek across ice and sea, tracking down its prey. However, Captain Carrick was reassigned to Vietnam before the tupilaq could reach him, forcing the construct creature to begin a long walk towards Southeast Asia. The *angakkuq* died without knowing of the monumental distances his creation traversed.

The tupilaq had almost reached its prey, when Carrick, now a major, was reassigned back to the US and went into politics. He traveled extensively, not knowing that his frequent flights kept him out of reach of the supernatural hunter tracking him. He finally died, somewhat ironically, of cancer. However, the rage, hatred, and anger that fueled the creature had not been sated and it began hunting down Carrick's nearest family.

The tupilaq is a 4-foot-high, puppet-like creature made of the bones of whales and musk oxen, as well as the skull of a dead child, all of it bound together with seal sinews. The creature's mouth is grotesquely distended and filled with hideous teeth carved from walrus ivory.

Character Involvement: The easiest way to involve the characters is to have one of them be the immediate family of Captain Carrick – a brother, sister, child, or grandchild (simply change the captain's name, if necessary). Or, one of the characters' ghouls, sire, childer, or close allies is related to Captain Carrick.

Attributes: Strength 4, Dexterity 3, Stamina 6, Charisma 0, Manipulation 0, Appearance 0, Perception 5, Intelligence 2, Wits 3

Abilities: Alertness 5, Athletics 5, Awareness 3, Brawl 5

Powers: Immune to bashing damage, soaks both lethal and aggravated with full Stamina. The tupilaq can sense the location of any immediate family of its target anywhere on Earth, though it can't see through Obfuscate or similar Disciplines. It is immune to all forms of mental or emotional control. It's bite does Strength +1 (aggravated to supernatural creatures) and the tupilaq can initiate a Clinch maneuver (see **V:tM20** page 276) with its bite. It is unaffected by Thaumaturgical Wards, but cannot attack anyone with Thaumaturgy or Necromancy 5 (though, with its creator dead, it will not be compelled to seek him out)

Health Levels: OK, OK, -1, -1, -1, -1, -1, -1, -1, -1, -1, Destroyed

8: Urban Spirit

While it is not something most vampires think about, they would not be surprised to learn that nature spirits are real. After all, if vampires, werewolves, and ghosts exist, why not spirits. What a lot of Kindred might find difficult to believe is that spirits also exist in urban settings. Even scholarly vampires with occult and esoteric interests are often unaware of the existence of city spirits – mainly because they are a lot less common. There is something about the urban landscape in the World of Darkness that is not conducive to spiritual development. However, from time to time, various factors intersect, giving rise to a spiritual entity.

This particular being was once a forest spirit, but its home was cut down to facilitate urban development. Normally, this would have resulted in the death of the spirit, but something kept it "alive" – some confluence of ley lines or spiritual energies. For decades, centuries, the spirit lay dormant, buried under concrete and roadways. But then, urban development and gentrification transformed the neighborhood, adding parks and other greenery. Slowly, the spirit awoke, changed by being forced into a city, weakened by the environment, but aware once again.

The spirit has been warped by the change in its environment and wants to make others feel the pain and madness that it feels. In the spirit world, the being looks like a warped and crooked tree, but it can also manifest as a huge pile of whatever garbage, detritus, fallen leaves, cut grass, and random sticks are around it.

The spirit uses Essence to power its Disciplines rather than blood – it can manifest at the cost of 5 Essence. It recovers Essence at the rate of one per day, at sunrise. The spirit can only use its physical Disciplines when corporeal, but at the cost of one additional Essence, the spirit can let a mental power manifest in the physical world. The spirit can also look from the spirit world into the physical world, seeing through Disciplines with the equivalent of Auspex 5. "Killing" the spirit's corporeal form simply reduces its Essence to 0 and discorporates it. In order to kill it, Disciplines that specifically target spirits must be employed.

Character Involvement: The characters can get involved with the spirit in a number of ways; it could haunt their domain, affect contacts, allies, or even ghouls, or it might even target a character who is hunting.

Another option is to have a sudden, strange outbreak of madness, violence, and suicides, which the characters might think is the work of the Sabbat or some rogue Malkavian.

The biggest problem is dealing with the spirit permanently. If the characters lack the ability to do so, they could end up needing to negotiate with Kindred who do have such powers, perhaps ending up owing some serious favors. Or, if one or more of the characters do have such powers, perhaps they are the ones being called upon, allowing them to negotiate their price.

Attributes: Strength 5, Dexterity 2, Stamina 5, Charisma 2, Manipulation 3, Appearance 0, Perception 4, Intelligence 2, Wits 4

Abilities: Alertness 5, Animal Ken 5, Athletics 3, Awareness 5, Brawl 3, Empathy 1, Expression 1, Intimidation 3, Occult 3, Stealth 1, Subterfuge 1, Survival 6

Equivalent Disciplines: Animalism 2, Dementation 4, Fortitude 5, Potence 3

Willpower: 9, **Essence Pool:** 15

9: Johann Metzner – Eternal Alchemist

Johann was born in the German city of Magdeburg at the end of the 16th century. His father was an extremely wealthy merchant and with Johann being his third son, he had no problem letting the young man take a university education rather than learn the family business. Johann attended the University of Leipzig, where he studied Astrology and the emerging sciences.

It was at the university that Johann met his mentor, Reinhardt von Hebenstreit, a master alchemist. Johann was enthralled by the possibilities that alchemy offered and dedicated much of his time to study and experimentation.

When von Hebenstreit died, Johann moved back to Magdeburg and, with his father's money, set himself up as an astrologer and alchemist. He made his money performing horoscopes for the city elite, but his true passion was alchemy. Over the decades, he made numerous experiments and even managed to perform some hitherto unknown transformations of matter.

Unbeknownst to Johann, his work was being observed by one of the city's vampires, a Tremere who saw a lot of potential in the alchemist. There were plans to induct Johann into the clan, when his usefulness as a mortal came to an end. Johann's would-be sire even posed as a fellow alchemist and brought Johann samples of Kindred Vitae, letting him know that it was vampire blood, to see what the man could do with it.

Unfortunately for the Kindred of Magdeburg, the city was invaded, sacked, and burned on the 20th of May 1631. Most of the city's vampires either died or were driven into torpor and most of the rest fled. And in all the chaos, Johann was forgotten.

For his part, Johann had begun to experiment with the Vitae he had been given and, with his previous advances in alchemy, he was able to create one of the grand works of alchemy; the potion of immortality.

For the next 100 years, Johann did not age. However, at the end of that century, the potion wore off. Being an intelligent and learned alchemist, Johann had known that this was a likely possibility and so, he had spent a lot of time learning as much as possible about vampires. And so, as his first potion wore off, Johann was able to secure himself more vitae and create another dose.

Over the centuries, Johann has perfected his alchemical craft. He has become fantastically rich, having invested money made as an astrologer and physician. These days, he is researching a more permanent potion of immortality – one that will require the expenditure of 100 points of vampiric blood.

Johann is a highly unremarkable man, short, dark-haired, dressed in a business suit. He carries on his person numerous alchemical items. He treads cautiously, as he has not survived through all those years without being careful and considerate – he also moves around a lot in order to avoid drawing too much attention.

Character Involvement: The easiest way for characters to become involved with Johann is for him to target them, one of their sires, or one of their childer for "Vitae extraction", though this would have to be at a time where said vampire is very weak – perhaps during the day.

However, Johann also knows a way to "distill" vitae from ghouls, so he might end up kidnapping one of the character's servants.

Finally, the characters might learn about Johann if one or more of them are involved in the occult. They will hear of someone new in town, buying up all manner of esoteric ingredients.

Attributes: Strength 3, Dexterity 3, Stamina 6, Charisma 3, Manipulation 4, Appearance 2, Perception 5, Intelligence 5, Wits 5

Abilities: Academics 4, Alertness 3, Athletics 2, Awareness 5, Crafts 5, Empathy 1, Etiquette 2, Finance 1, Intimidation 1, Larceny 3, Medicine 3, Melee 3, Occult 5, Science 5, Streetwise 4, Subterfuge 4

Humanity: 6, **Willpower:** 10

Equipment: Suit (counts as 5 levels of armor, no penalty), dagger (does Str+3 damage), saber (does Str+4 aggravated), long-term alchemical effects (equal to Fortitude 3, also heals 1 bashing damage per round and 1 lethal damage per minute), several healing potions (heals all normal damage or one Aggravated), crystal prism (allows Johann to identify the presence of vampiric vitae in anyone examined through it).

10: Azarakh Brain Bug

Few Kindred known that azarakhs exist and none of them know what these beings are. Some have theories, but none of those theories fully explain everything about the so-called "Brain Bugs". Even the name, azarakh, comes only from some fragment of lore handed down by occultists through the millennia.

What is known is that azarakhs are arachnid creatures that exist in the spirit world, until they attach themselves to a mortal host. Once this happens, they enter the physical realm, though they are invisible to anyone without supernatural senses. Azarakhs seem to feed off negative, psychic energy and as such, they drive their "hosts" to perform all manner of brutal, sadistic, and taboo acts.

Azarakhs can only possess mortal beings, though this includes ghouls. It is unknown whether or not they can possess lupines – kindred who know about the brain bugs fervently hope not. In order to possess a mortal, an azarakh latches onto the person's spiritual reflection and the Storyteller rolls 10 dice (difficulty of the target's Willpower), while the target resists with Willpower (base difficulty is 6, but the more negative a person's mood is, the higher the difficulty).

If successful, the brain bug materializes as a spider-like creature, the size of a housecat, perched on the victim's head, its fangs sunk into the skull. The azarakh is concealed by an effect equal to Obfuscate 3, so anyone who can see through that level of Obfuscate can see the creature (on a resisted roll, the azarakh has 6 dice). The bug cannot defend itself, other than by forcing its host to act. It has 2 soak dice against bashing and lethal damage and nothing against aggravated, tough attacking it is at +2 difficulty due to its size and the movement of the host. The azarakh has 3 health levels and if killed in the physical realm, it is dead. It takes one full combat turn for an azarakh to detach itself and become a spirit creature once more.

Once per day, an azarakh can try to force its host to perform some kind of vile, unnatural, stressful, or taboo-breaking act. The host can resist by spending 1 point of Willpower, but this Willpower cannot be regained until the azarakh is detached. Once the victim's Willpower is depleted, the brain bug is in full control of its victim.

There is strong evidence that azarakhs can not only sense each other's' presence, but also communicate telepathically. When several brain bug victims congregate, they act with remarkable coordination, but without communication.

No Kindred has ever successfully communicated directly with an azarakh – some have knowingly spoken to a host, but they seem to try and tell anyone interviewing or interrogating them what the asking party wants to hear. The ultimate goal of the brain bugs is completely unknown and some Kindred have become quite paranoid thinking about whom among the world's leading mortals might be infected.

Character Involvement: In addition to having one of the character's contacts, allies, or ghouls infected by a brain bug, it might also be interesting to simply have a character with sufficient Auspex notice an azarakh on a random mortal and see how they react and how they try to convince their allies that yes, that lady does in fact have a giant spider on her head.

11: The Ifrit

According to the Qur'an, the Ifrit are infernal Jinn and the most powerful Jinn to walk the earth. They are death spirits, who dwell in Jahannam, the underworld where the wicked and evil are punished. However, they are easily drawn to Earth, as they feed on the life force and blood of murder victims. Once having done so, they take on the physical appearance of the murder victim at the point of their death and are compelled to hunt down the murderer. Once they have killed the murderer, the Ifrit can chose to remain on earth or return to Jahannam. If they remain on Earth, they are compelled to inhabit desolate places, like uninhabited caves or ruins.

This particular Ifrit was drawn to Earth in Iraq. A platoon of soldiers, searching a town for insurgent fighters, was ambushed. Half the platoon's members died in the ambush, but they eventually prevailed. The unit commander, a very green second lieutenant, survived, but lost his mind and demanded that the townsfolk were rounded up and executed for the crime of not warning the soldiers of the ambush. When his men refused, the lieutenant first threatened them with a court-martial, before drawing his sidearm and threatening to shoot his own troops. In response, two of the men fired their rifles, wounding the officer. After a brief consultation, all the remaining men gathered up the AK rifles of the enemy and shot the lieutenant at the same time, so that they were all complicit. They then reported their commander killed by enemy fire.

As with any Jinn, an Ifrit can be either a believer or an unbeliever, good or evil. The Ifrit that rose to sup upon the blood and fading life-force of the dying second lieutenant is most definitely both an unbeliever and a wicked, ruthless, and evil being. It stalked the lieutenant's murderers, killing the first two (the initial shooters) while they were still in Iraq. When the rest of the soldiers transferred out, the Ifrit followed them. The creature stalks its victim slowly, terrorizing its target before killing them. It has killed all but one of the soldiers and the man in question knows quite well that all his old squadmates are dead. He is unaware what is hunting him, but he knows, without a shadow of a doubt, that his platoon was cursed back there in that town whose name he's forgotten.

The Ifrit appears as a young man with crew-cut hair and a slightly caricatured, overly-military bearing and manner. He has numerous bullet-wounds in his back and torso, which slowly trickle blood. When readying to kill (or defend itself), the Ifrit takes on a terrifying aspect, with smokeless flame leaping from its mouth, black horns curling from its forehead and claws forming at the end of its fingers. The Ifrit uses Essence to power its Disciplines and can use it to heal wounds in the same was as vampires use Vitae. It regains all Essence and heals all damage (even Aggravated) at nightfall. The Ifrit can soak all damage with its full Stamina + Fortitude and is immune to fire, mind control and emotional influences, though not the madness of Dementation.

A faithful Muslim can cause an Ifrit to discorporate and return to Jahannam by invoking Allah in a short Du'a (prayer of supplication). Likewise, a Christian can force an Ifrit to flee by crossing himself and a Jew can make an Ifrit flee by invoking King Solomon. In all these cases, True Faith is not needed, but the person in question must actually be a follower of the religion in question.

When not actively seeking out its quarry or terrorizing the target, the Ifrit will dwell in a ruined house, abandoned factory, or other desolate place.

Character Involvement: The easiest way to involve the character is to have the Ifrit's last victim be an ally, ghoul, or even prospective childe of one of the characters. Alternately, the characters may chance upon the Ifrit terrorizing its target, promising a painful death.

Attributes: Strength 4, Dexterity 4, Stamina 4, Charisma 4, Manipulation 1, Appearance 3/0, Perception 5, Intelligence 2, Wits 4

Abilities: Alertness 5, Athletics 5, Awareness 3, Brawl 5, Empathy 3, Intimidation 5, Occult 3, Stealth 3, Subterfuge 5, Theology 3

Equivalent Disciplines: Auspex 2, Celerity 1, Fortitude 3, Potence 3, Thaumaturgy (Lure of Flames) 3

Willpower: 7, **Essence Pool:** 20